3.4. Case study: identifying tech debt trending with project tracking data

Now that we've talked about this data and have it populating our graphs, I'll share a real-world scenario where this data alone helped a team come to terms with a problem, make adjustments, and get to a better place.

Our team was using Scrum and had a two-week sprint cadence. We were working on a release that had a rather large and interrelated set of features with many stakeholders. As with most teams, we started with tracking velocity to ensure that we were consistently estimating and completing our work every sprint. We did this so we could trust our estimates enough to be able to deliver more predictably over time and so stakeholders could get an idea of approximately when the whole set of features they wanted would be delivered.

In this case we couldn't hit a consistent number of story points at the end of every sprint. To complicate things we didn't have a typical colocated small agile team; we had two small teams in different time zones that were working toward the same large product launch.

In summary the current state of the team was:

- Geographically distributed team working toward the same goal
- Agile development of a large interrelated feature set

We were asking these questions:

- Why are we not normalizing on a consistent velocity?
- What can we do to become more predictable for our stakeholders?

The goal was to maintain a consistent velocity so we could communicate more effectively to our stakeholders what they could expect to test by the end of every sprint. The velocity of the team is shown in figure 3.17.

Figure 3.17. Story points are jumping all over the place.